Opinion Formation on Networks: A Review of the DeGroot model and Its Extensions

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Abstract—Understanding how opinions emerge and evolve within a population is central to explaining collective behavior and social dynamics. In this review paper, we take a closer look at the DeGroot model (1974) and analyze its convergence and network properties. We show that the model converges to a consensus if the weight/adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ is primitive. We also prove that this condition can be verified by checking whether the corresponding graph is strongly connected and aperiodic. Moreover, we show that the connectedness of the graph provides an upper and lower bound for the second largest eigenvalue of $\boldsymbol{A}$, which in turn gives us an upper bound for the convergence speed of the model. Finally, we take a look at the Friedkin-Johnsen model (1990, 1999) and a bounded-confidence model. For the former, we show that the model converges if the product $\boldsymbol{DA}$ of the *susceptibility* matrix $\boldsymbol{D}$ and $\boldsymbol{A}$ is irreducible. For the latter, we provide a procedure to ensure the convergence of the model.

1 Introduction

As individuals interact and exchange views, local patterns of agreement or disagreement can propagate through social networks, leading to large-scale outcomes such as consensus, polarization, or fragmentation. The question of how, for example, echo chambers form and influence opinions is a strongly debated topic in our society.

In order to better understand these phenomena, many attempts have been made to analyze and model the formation of opinions, like voter and Ising models, as well as Friedkin and Johnsen (1990, [1]). Another well-known example is the DeGroot Model (1974, [2]) which presents a rather simple, iterative process. Given an instance of this model, we can then analyze or calculate properties such as whether the group will reach a consensus (see in section 3.1.1 and section 3.1.2), what the consensus they will reach (see in section 3.1.3), and how fast they will reach it (see in section 3.1.4). Moreover, the model can be represented and visualized as a graph with the nodes and edges representing, who is communicating with whom. Thereby, we can use features of these graphs as conditions and explanations for the before mentioned properties (see in section 3.2).

As the DeGroot model is a rather simple abstraction of opinion formation in real social networks, it does not capture all aspects of social interaction. Therefore, we will take a look at two extensions of the DeGroot Model (see in section 4), first the before mentioned Friedkin-Johnsen model and second the Hegselmann-Krause model.

2 Preliminaries and Notation

In this paper, we use $\mathbf{1}$ to denote the vector with all-ones and $\boldsymbol{I}$ to denote the identity matrix. Similarly, the vector with all-zeros is referred to as $\mathbf{0}$. We use the following style for vectors $\boldsymbol{p}$, matrices $\boldsymbol{M}$, and graphs $\mathcal{G}$. Moreover $V(\mathcal{G})$ denotes the set of vertices and $E(\mathcal{G})$ the set of edges in $\mathcal{G}$. For a matrix $\boldsymbol{M}$, the notation $(M)_{ij}$ refers to the entry in the ith row and jth column of $\boldsymbol{M}$. Furthermore, we use the notation $\underline{n} = \{1, \dots, n\}$.

A row-stochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{A} \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$ is defined, such that for all its entries $a_{ij} \geq 0$ and its row vectors sum up to 1, i.e. $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij} = 1$ for all $i \in \underline{n}$. A row-substochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{A} \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$ is a non-negative matrix with at least one row vector that sums up to less than 1, i.e. $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij} \leq 1$ for all $j \in \underline{n}$ and $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij} < 1$ for at least one $j \in \underline{n}$. Furthermore, a digraph describes a directed graph, meaning every edge has a direction. A graph is strongly connected if and only if every node $v \in V(\mathcal{G})$ is reachable from every other node $u \in V(\mathcal{G})$ (with $v \neq u$), i.e. there exists a directed path from every node u to v. A sink $\mathcal{S}$ is a strongly connected subgraph, i.e. $V(\mathcal{S}) \subset V(\mathcal{G})$ and $E(\mathcal{S}) \subset E(\mathcal{G})$, that has no node $i \in \mathcal{S}$, such that there exists a node $j \notin \mathcal{S}$ with $(i,j) \in E(\mathcal{G})$. Lastly, a graph is aperiodic if and only if there exists no $k \in \mathbb{N}_{>1}$, that divides the length of every simple cycle of the graph. A simple cycle refers to every possible path from any node v back to itself.

3 DeGroot model

The DeGroot model considers a group of n individuals who discuss their own opinions on a given parameter θ, that describes the subject, with one another. Each of these individuals has their own opinion value for this unknown parameter θ which we will refer to as v_i for $i \in \underline{n}$. The model makes use of the idea that interaction with other people in the group, can cause an individual i to change their opinion value v_i based on new information or expertise provided by the other individuals.

The model assumes that this revision of the individual's opinion is a linear combination of the opinion values $v_1, \dots, v_n$. To model this revision, we therefore define a_{ij} which denotes the weight that individual i assigns to the opinion of individual j. If, for example, individual j is a leading expert on the value of θ, then individual i might want to assign a greater weight to individual j's opinion.

Likewise, individual i can also assign a large weight to their own opinion and a small total weight to the opinions of other individuals. Another possible approach would be to weigh those opinions highly which align the most with one's own opinion. The weights are assigned by the individuals without any knowledge of the other individuals' assigned weights.

Let v_{ik} denote the opinion value of individual i after revision k, then a revised opinion value of the individual i is calculated as

$$v_{ik} = \sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij} v_{j(k-1)} \ . \tag{1}$$

It is assumed that $a_{ij} \geq 0$ and $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij} = 1$, meaning the weights assigned by a each individual sum up to 1, therefore the matrix representing the weights

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a_{11} & \dots & a_{1n} \\ \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ a_{n1} & \dots & a_{nn} \end{bmatrix},$$

is row-stochastic, as all its entries are non-negative and its rows have unit sum.

If we let the vector $\boldsymbol{p_0} = (v_1, \dots, v_n)^\mathsf{T}$ denote the initial opinion values and $\boldsymbol{p_k} = (v_{1k}, \dots, v_{nk})^\mathsf{T}$ denote the opinion values after k revisions, we can express a given revision as

$$\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{A p_{k-1}} = \boldsymbol{A}^k \boldsymbol{p_0} \ , \tag{2}$$

for $k = 1, 2, \dots$. This process of revising the opinions is then repeated until the vector $\boldsymbol{p}_k$ has converged for a large enough number of revisions k, with

$$\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{p_{k+1}} = \boldsymbol{A p_k} \ . \tag{3}$$

As $\boldsymbol{A p_k} = \boldsymbol{A}^k \boldsymbol{p_0}$, see eq. (2), it follows that

$$\boldsymbol{A}^k \boldsymbol{A p_0} = \boldsymbol{A}^k \boldsymbol{p_0} \ , \tag{4}$$

i.e. $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{A}^k$ converges. We will refer to this converged matrix as $\boldsymbol{A^{fin}}$ and to the converged opinion values as $\boldsymbol{p^{fin}} = (v_1^{fin}, \dots, v_n^{fin})$. [2]

3.1 Convergence properties

When the opinion values have converged after a large enough number of k revisions, as seen in eq. (2), we can stop the iterative revision process. If the value of all n components in $\boldsymbol{p^{fin}}$ are identical, with $v_1^{fin} = \dots = v_n^{fin}$, then the n individuals of the group have reached an identical opinion value. In this case, we say that the group has reached a consensus.

With this definition of a consensus, we can now answer four central questions in the following subsections:

1) When does the model converge?
2) When is consensus reached?
3) What consensus is reached?
4) How can we measure the speed of convergence?

3.1.1 Convergence of the DeGroot model

To determine when a consensus is reached, we first have to ensure that the model converges. As seen in eq. (4), this is true, if $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{A}^k$ exists. However, this does not always have to be the case, as can be seen in the following example.

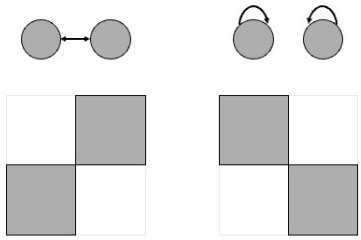


Fig. 1. Top: The given graph. Bottom: A heatmap of the corresponding adjacency matrix

If the row-stochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{M}$, shown on the left in fig. 1, is multiplied by itself, it takes the form that is shown on the left for uneven powers $\boldsymbol{M}^{2k+1}$, and the form on the right for even powers $\boldsymbol{M}^{2k}$. Therefore, $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{M}^k$ does not exist. The real-world counterpart for this example would be a pair of individuals who swap their two opinions at each revision.

Every square matrix $\boldsymbol{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ is similar to a block diagonal matrix $\boldsymbol{J} \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$, also called the Jordan normal form of $\boldsymbol{A}$, meaning $\boldsymbol{A} = \boldsymbol{TJT}^{-1}$ for an invertible matrix $\boldsymbol{T} \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$. This Jordan matrix consists of so-called Jordan blocks, where each block $\boldsymbol{J}_i$ has the form

$$\boldsymbol{J}_i^k = \begin{bmatrix} \lambda_i & 1 & 0 & \dots & 0 \\ 0 & \lambda_i & \ddots & \ddots & \vdots \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & \ddots & 0 & \lambda_i & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & 0 & \lambda_i \end{bmatrix},$$

where λ_i is the ith eigenvalue of $\boldsymbol{A}$. The size of a Jordan block J_i is equal to the dimension of the eigenspace of the corresponding eigenvalue.

As $\boldsymbol{A}^k = \boldsymbol{TJ}^k\boldsymbol{T}^{-1}$, we can use this equation to find the limit of $\boldsymbol{A}^k$, as $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{A}^k = \lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{TJ}^k\boldsymbol{T}^{-1}$. Therefore, it suffices to show that $\boldsymbol{J}^k$ converges, to prove that $\boldsymbol{A}^k$ converges.

As the kth power of a Jordan block $\boldsymbol{J}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{l\times l}$ with the eigenvalue λ_i has the form

$$\boldsymbol{J}_i^k = \begin{bmatrix} \lambda_i^k & \binom{k}{1}\lambda_i^{k-1} & \binom{k}{2}\lambda_i^{k-2} & \dots & \binom{k}{l-1}\lambda_i^{k-l+1} \\ 0 & \lambda_i^k & \binom{k}{1}\lambda_i^{k-1} & \ddots & \vdots \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & \binom{k}{2}\lambda_i^{k-2} \\ 0 & \ddots & 0 & \lambda_i^k & \binom{k}{1}\lambda_i^{k-1} \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & 0 & \lambda_i^k \end{bmatrix},$$

see [3], we can conclude the following conditions for the convergence of matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$. First, all of its eigenvalues λ_i need to be in the intervall $-1 < |\lambda_i| \leq 1$. If $|\lambda_i| > 1$ then all non-zero entries of $\boldsymbol{J_i}$ diverge for $\lim_{k\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{J_i}^k)_{ij} = \infty$. When some Jordan block J_i diverges for $\lim_{k\to\infty}$ then trivially the Jordan matrix and thus $\boldsymbol{A}$ diverge as well. Moreover,

if $\lambda_j = -1$ is an eigenvalue of $\boldsymbol{A}$, then the entries λ_j on the diagonal of the corresponding Jordan block $\boldsymbol{J_j}$ diverge for $\lim_{k\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{J_i^k})_{ij}$, as the powers λ_j^k oscillate between -1 and 1. Thus, $\boldsymbol{A}$ oscillates as well, as can be seen in fig. 1. Second, if 1 is an eigenvalue of $\boldsymbol{A}$, it needs to be semisimple, meaning that its geometric and algebraic multiplicities are equal, i.e. the corresponding Jordan block $\boldsymbol{J}_1$ has size 1. If this condition is not satisfied, the entries $(J)_{ij}$ with $j > i$ diverge for $\lim_{k\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{J_i^k})_{ij} = \infty$. In the following, we will refer to the eigenvalue 1 of $\boldsymbol{A}$, also called the dominant eigenvalue, as λ_1. Moreover, because T is invertible, we know that $\boldsymbol{T}, \boldsymbol{T}^{-1} \neq \boldsymbol{0_{n\times n}}$. Therefore, if $\boldsymbol{A}$ has the semisimple eigenvalue λ_1, then

$$\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{A}^k = \boldsymbol{T}(\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{J}^k)\boldsymbol{T}^{-1} \neq \boldsymbol{0_{n\times n}} \ ,$$

as the singular value in the Jordan block $\lim_{k\to\infty} J_1$ converges against 1, i.e. $\lim_{k\to\infty} J^k \neq \boldsymbol{0_{n\times n}}$. We refer to such a matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ as semi-convergent. Because $\boldsymbol{A}$ is row-stochastic, by definition

$$\boldsymbol{A1} = \boldsymbol{1} = 1 \cdot \boldsymbol{1}, \text{with } \boldsymbol{1} \neq \boldsymbol{0} \ , \tag{5}$$

as all rows have unit sum. Thus, λ_1 is an eigenvalue of all matrices $\boldsymbol{A}$ of our model which are consequentially semi-convergent, if a limit exists.

We can summarize these findings in the following theorem 3.1.

Theorem 3.1. *A squared matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ is semi-convergent (i.e. $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{A}^k \neq \boldsymbol{0_{n\times n}}$ exists) if and only if:*

(i) 1 is an eigenvalue
(ii) 1 a semisimple eigenvalue, and
(iii) all other eigenvalues have magnitude less than 1.

As we showed, condition (i) of theorem 3.1 holds for all row-stochastic matrices. We will discuss under which circumstances the other conditions hold in the following section.

3.1.2 Reaching a consensus

To now determine when a consensus is reached, we will utilize the Perron-Frobenius theorem 3.2, namely irreducible and primitive matrices.

Definition 3.1 (Irreducible and primitive matrices)**.** *For $n \geq 2$, a non-negative matrix $\boldsymbol{A} \in \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}^{n\times n}$ is*

(i) irreducible if $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \boldsymbol{A}^k > 0$
(ii) primitive if there exists a $k \in \mathbb{N}$, such that $\boldsymbol{A}^k > 0$.

Moreover, being primitive is a sufficient condition for an irreducible matrix.

If we apply the Perron-Frobenius Theorem to row-stochastic matrices $\boldsymbol{A}$, we get the following.

Theorem 3.2 (Perron-Frobenius Theorem)**.** *Let the row-stochastic $\boldsymbol{A} \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$ with $n \geq 2$, then if $\boldsymbol{A}$ is irreducible,*

(i) the eigenvalue λ_1 is simple.

If additionally $\boldsymbol{A}$ is primitive, then

(i) the eigenvalue λ_1 satisfies $\lambda_1 > |\lambda_i|$ for all other eigenvalues of $\boldsymbol{A}$.

Therefore, according to the Perron-Frobenius theorem 3.2, if $\boldsymbol{A}$ is irreducible and row-stochastic, then λ_1 is simple which is a sufficient condition for semisimple, thus fulfilling condition (ii) of theorem 3.1. Moreover, if additionally $\boldsymbol{A}$ is primitive, then all eigenvalues $\lambda_i \neq 1$ have magnitude less than 1, i.e. $\lambda_1 > |\lambda_i|$, thus fulfilling condition (iii) of theorem 3.1. We can therefore conclude that a row-stochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ is semi-convergent if it is primitive.

However, it can often be computationally expensive to check whether a given matrix is irreducible or primitive. Therefore, we will now relate these conditions to graph properties, which are typically easier to verify.

We can translate any instance of the DeGroot model into a digraph $\mathcal{G} = (V, E)$ with the nodes $V(\mathcal{G}) = \{1, \dots, n\}$ representing the individuals and the edges $E(\mathcal{G}) = \{(i,j)|a_{ij} > 0\}$ with the corresponding weighted adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$, defined in section 3. We can now observe that a path of length k exists from node i to node j in $\mathcal{G}$ if and only if the entry (i,j) of the kth power of the adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A}^k$ is positive.

Proof. Let $\boldsymbol{A} \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$. There trivially exists a path of length 1 from node i to node j, precisely when $(A)_{ij} = a_{ij} > 0$, i.e. there exists an edge from i to j. Assume that the observation is correct for any $k \in \underline{n}$. If there exists a path of length $k+1$ from i to j, then there exists a path of length k from i to some node $l \in \underline{n}$ with $(l,j) \in E(\mathcal{G})$, i.e. $(\boldsymbol{A})_{lj} > 0$. As $(\boldsymbol{A}^{k+1})_{ij} = (\boldsymbol{A}^k \cdot \boldsymbol{A})_{ij} = \sum_{m=1}^{n} (\boldsymbol{A}^k)_{im} \cdot (\boldsymbol{A})_{mj} \geq (\boldsymbol{A}^k)_{il} \cdot (\boldsymbol{A})_{lj} > 0$, because by the induction hypothesis $(\boldsymbol{A}^k)_{il} > 0$. In the other direction, if $(\boldsymbol{A}^{k+1})_{ij} > 0$ then their must be at least one $l \in \underline{n}$, such that $(\boldsymbol{A}^k)_{il} \cdot (\boldsymbol{A})_{lj} > 0$. Thus, using the induction hypothesis, there must exist a path of length k from i to l and $(l,j) \in E(\mathcal{G})$. Therefore, there exists a path of length $k+1$ from i to j over l. □

This means that our digraph $\mathcal{G}$ is strongly connected, if and only if for every pair of nodes (i,j) with $i \neq j$, $(\boldsymbol{A}^k)_{ij} > 0$, for a $k < n$. It trivially suffices to ensure this property for $k < n$, as if a path of length $k \geq n$ exists, then at least $n+1$ nodes are visited, i.e. at least one node is visited multiple times. consequentially, a loop exists in this path which can be removed, resulting in a path of length $k < n$. Thus $\mathcal{G}$ is strongly connected if and only if $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} \boldsymbol{A}^k > 0$, i.e. $\boldsymbol{A}$ is irreducible, see definition 3.1. Moreover, as shown in [3], the weighted adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ is primitive if and only if $\mathcal{G}$ is strongly connected and aperiodic.

Now we can examine when the model reaches consensus. As we have stated, all eigenvalues of a row-stochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ must have a magnitude less than 1, except for the eigenvalue λ_1, for $\boldsymbol{A}^k$ to converge. Moreover, the eigenvalue λ_1 needs to be semisimple, such that the corresponding Jordan blocks converge.

Therefore, we know that if we let m_g denote the geometric multiplicity (and thus also the algebraic multiplicity) of eigenvalue λ_1, then the limit of the Jordan matrix $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{J}^k$ is a diagonal matrix with m_g 1's on the diagonal, corresponding to the Jordan blocks. For $m_g \in \underline{n}$, let $\boldsymbol{c_1}, \dots, \boldsymbol{c_{m_g}}$ denote the columns of $\boldsymbol{T}$ and $\boldsymbol{r_1}, \dots, \boldsymbol{r_{m_g}}$ denote the rows of $\boldsymbol{T}^{-1}$ that correspond to the Jordan blocks for the eigenvalue λ_1. Moreover, let c_{ij} and r_{ij} denote the jth entry of these vectors. Then

$$\boldsymbol{T}(\lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{J}^k)\boldsymbol{T}^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix}\boldsymbol{c_1} & \dots & \boldsymbol{c_{m_g}}\end{bmatrix}\cdot\begin{bmatrix}\boldsymbol{r_1} & \dots & \boldsymbol{r_{m_g}}\end{bmatrix}^\mathsf{T}$$
$$= \begin{bmatrix}c_{11} & \dots & c_{m_g 1}\\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots \\ c_{1n} & \dots & c_{m_g n}\end{bmatrix}\cdot\begin{bmatrix}r_{11} & \dots & r_{1n}\\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots \\ r_{m_g 1} & \dots & r_{m_g n}\end{bmatrix} \quad (6)$$

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To reach asymptotic consensus, all rows of $\boldsymbol{A^{fin}}$ need to be equal. Thus all columns $\boldsymbol{c_1},\dots,\boldsymbol{c_{m_g}}$ of $\boldsymbol{T}$ need to be equal, see eq. (6).

As $\boldsymbol{A} = \boldsymbol{TJT^{-1}} \iff \boldsymbol{AT} = \boldsymbol{TJ} \iff \boldsymbol{T^{-1}A} = \boldsymbol{JT^{-1}}$, if $\boldsymbol{A}$ is semisimple, then $\boldsymbol{Ac}_i = \lambda_i \boldsymbol{c}_i$ and $\boldsymbol{r}_i\boldsymbol{A} = \lambda_i \boldsymbol{r}_i$, i.e. $\boldsymbol{c}_i$ is the right eigenvector and $\boldsymbol{r}_i$ the left eigenvector of λ_i. As the number of dimensions of an eigenspace is equal to the geometric multiplicity of the corresponding eigenvalue, the eigenspace of λ_1 has m_g dimensions. Thus, all of the m_g eigenvectors c_i of λ_1 need to be linearly independent. Therefore, they cannot be equal if the geometric multiplicity $m_g > 1$, meaning the rows of $\boldsymbol{A^{fin}}$ are equal if and only if $m_g = 1$, i.e. λ_1 is simple.

Thus, our model reaches asymptotic consensus if and only if the row-stochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ is semi-convergent and λ_1 is simple. Therefore, according to the Perron-Frobenius theorem 3.2 the model converges when $\boldsymbol{A}$ is primitive. However, $\boldsymbol{A}$ being primitive is not a necessary condition for reaching asymptotic consensus. Intuitively, as all final opinion values are dependant on the individual i corresponding to the simple eigenvalue λ_1, all other individuals need to be connected to this individual i. Otherwise, their opinion value could not be influence by individual i. Thus, the node corresponding to individual i needs to be globaly reachable, i.e. reachable from all other nodes. In other words, there needs to exist a globaly reachable node, which precisely corresponds to λ_1, for the model to asymptotically reach a consensus.

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3.1.3 Calculating the consensus

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However, we are not only interested in the conditions for the model to converge against a consensus, but also in what consensus is reached. Therefore, we will take a look at how the consensus can be calculated, in case it is reached.

As we concluded in section 3.1.2, the model converges to a consensus if and only if $\boldsymbol{A}$ is semi-convergent and λ_1 is simple. Thus, using eq. (6), $\lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{A}^k = \boldsymbol{c}\cdot\boldsymbol{r}$, where $\boldsymbol{c} = [c_1,\dots,c_n]^\mathsf{T}$ and $\boldsymbol{r} = [r_1,\dots,r_n]$ are the right and left eigenvectors of λ_1.

If we now choose $\boldsymbol{c} = \boldsymbol{1}$, then

$$\lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{A}^k = \boldsymbol{1r} = \begin{bmatrix}\boldsymbol{r}\\ \vdots \\ \boldsymbol{r}\end{bmatrix}_{n\times n} = \begin{bmatrix}r_1 & r_2 & \dots & r_n\\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & \vdots \\ r_1 & r_2 & \dots & r_n\end{bmatrix}. \quad (7)$$

To calculate the consensus, we now need to combine this eq. (7) with eq. (2), such that

$$\boldsymbol{p^{fin}} = \lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{p}^k = (\lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{A}^k)\boldsymbol{p}_0 = \begin{bmatrix}\boldsymbol{r}\\ \vdots \\ \boldsymbol{r}\end{bmatrix}_{n\times n}\begin{bmatrix}v_1\\ \vdots \\ v_n\end{bmatrix}. \quad (8)$$

Therefore, the consensus is equal to

$$r_1v_1 + r_2v_2 + \dots + r_nv_n.$$

To summarize, we only require the left eigenvector $\boldsymbol{r}$ of λ_1 of the matrix $\boldsymbol{A^{fin}}$, in addition to the vector of the initial opinion values $\boldsymbol{p}_0$.

3.1.4 Measuring the speed of convergence

Finally, after analyzing when and what consensus is reached, we will examine whether we can measure the speed of convergence, i.e. how long it takes the group to reach a consensus.

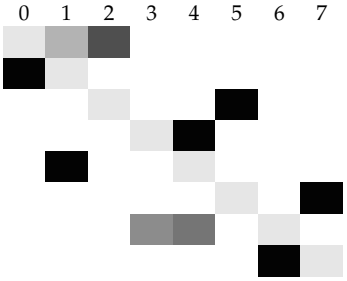
Rather intuitively, we can observe that the speed of convergence is dependent on the eigenvalues of matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$. As we have shown in section 3.1.1, the convergence of A can be represented by its Jordan matrix $\boldsymbol{A}^k = \boldsymbol{TJ}^k\boldsymbol{T}^{-1}$. The matrix $\boldsymbol{J}^k$ converges when all eigenvalues $|\lambda_i| < 1$, i.e. all eigenvalues except $\lambda = 1$, converge against 0, with $\lim_{k\to\infty}\lambda_i^k = 0$. Therefore, the speed of convergence is dependent on the size of the eigenvalues of $\boldsymbol{A}$. More specifically, if we order the eigenvalue of $\boldsymbol{A}$, with $-1 \le |\lambda_{m_g}| \le \dots \le |\lambda_2| \le |\lambda_1| = 1$, then the speed is dependent on the size of the second largest eigenvalue λ_2. As argued in [4], the eigenvalue λ_{m_g} is not as relevant, because adding self-loops to each node would result in a positive semi-definite adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$ and thus in strictly non-negative eigenvalues. For such a construction, it trivially holds that $\lambda_2^k \ge \lambda_i^k$, with $k > 0$, for all eigenvalues. Therefore, we can define the upper bound

$$|v_{ik} - \boldsymbol{rp_0}| = O(\lambda_2^k)\ .\ [5]$$

This bound describes that the distance between all opinion values at revision k and the final opinion value is dependent on the size of the eigenvalue λ_2. Thus, we know for all pairs of semi-convergent, row-stochastic matrices $\boldsymbol{A}$ and $\boldsymbol{A}'$, that if $\lambda_2 < \lambda_2'$, then $\lim_{k\to\infty}\boldsymbol{A}^k$ converges faster than $\lim_{k\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{A}')^k$. This can be observed in fig. 2 and fig. 3. The eigenvalue λ_2 of the adjacency matrix used in fig. 2 is far smaller than the one of the adjacency matrix used in fig. 3. Thus, the model in fig. 2 converges after approximately 80 revision, while the model in fig. 3 already converges after only about 7 revisions.

Therefore, we can measure the convergence rate by calculating the difference between $\lambda_1 - \lambda_2$. This eigengap between the dominant eigenvalue λ_1 and λ_2 is also referred to as the spectral gap. Because of its relevance, this eigenvalue is often called the Fiedler eigenvalue in other literature.

TABLE 1
Adjacency matrix used in fig. 2 with $\lambda_2 \approx -0.718$.



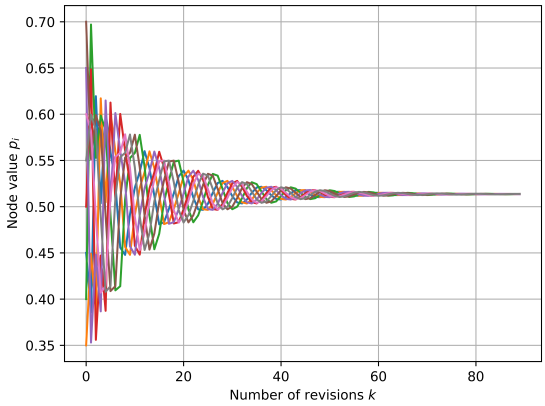


Fig. 2. The convergence towards a consensus for a model with the adjacency matrix shown in table 1.

TABLE 2
Adjacency matrix used in fig. 3 with $\lambda_2 \approx 0.433$.

	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
0								
1								
2								
3								
4								
5								
6								
7								

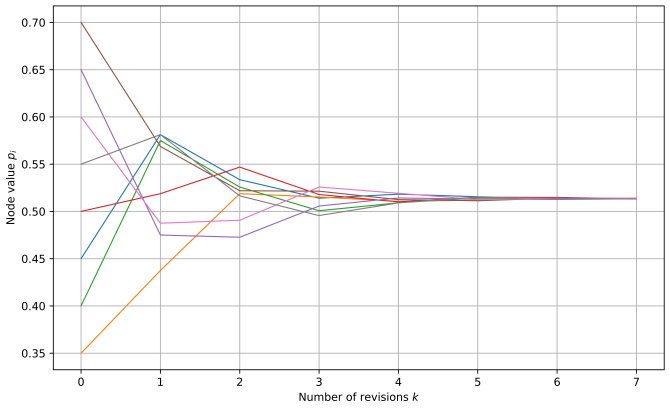


Fig. 3. The convergence towards a consensus for a model with the adjacency matrix shown in table 2.

3.2 Influence of network properties on the convergence

As shown in section 3.1.2, we can represent the DeGroot model as a digraph $\mathcal{G}$ with the individuals as nodes and $\boldsymbol{A}$ as the weighted adjacency matrix. Therefore, we will look at how certain network/graph properties can influence the model.

First, we will look at graphs $\mathcal{G}$ that consist of multiple strongly connected subgraphs $\mathcal{G}_i$, i.e. $\mathcal{G}_i(E) \subset \mathcal{G}(E)$ and $\mathcal{G}_i(V) \subset \mathcal{G}(V)$. As shown in section 3.1.2, the model reaches a consensus if and only if a globally reachable node exists. Thus no consensus is reached for these graphs $\mathcal{G}$, as such a node cannot exist by definition. However, according to [3], the eigenvalue λ_1 is semisimple with multiplicity m_g and $|\lambda_i| < 1$ for all $i \in \underline{n}$ if and only if $\mathcal{G}$ has sinks $\mathcal{S}_i$, see section 2, with $i \in \underline{m_g}$, that are all aperiodic. Such graphs $\mathcal{G}$, that fulfill these conditions, therefore have semi-convergent adjacency matrices $\boldsymbol{A}$, see theorem 3.1. These graphs $\mathcal{G}$ reach disagreement, instead of consensus, meaning that at least one pair of final opinion values $v_i^{fin} \neq v_j^{fin}$, with $i \neq j$. When calculating the final opinion values, we need to differentiate between strongly connected subgraphs and sinks. As the sinks $\mathcal{S}_i$ have no outgoing edges, the final opinion values of individuals in the sinks are not dependent on other individuals outside of their sink. Therefore, the final opinion value for nodes $j \in \mathcal{S}_i$, with $i \in \underline{m_g}$, can be calculated as

$$v_j^{fin} = \boldsymbol{r}_i \boldsymbol{p_0},$$

where $\boldsymbol{r_i}$ is the corresponding left eigenvector, like in eq. (8). However, the final opinion values of strongly connected subgraphs that are not sinks, i.e. that have outgoing edges to other strongly connected subgraphs, are dependent on nodes outside of their subgraph. Therefore, the final opinion value for nodes $j \notin \mathcal{S}_i$, with $i \in \underline{m_g}$, are equal to

$$v_j^{fin} = \sum_{p=1}^{m_g} z_{jp}(\boldsymbol{r_i} \boldsymbol{p_0}) \ ,$$

where $\boldsymbol{r_i}$ is the corresponding left eigenvector and z_{jp}, with $p \in \underline{m_g}$, are convex combination coefficients that are $z_{jp} > 0$ if and only if there exists a directed path from node j to sink p. [3]

Second, we will discuss how the connectedness of the graph can influence the convergence rate of the model. The conductance Φ of a graph $\mathcal{G}$ is a measure to determine how connected a graph is. For a set S of nodes, this measure is defined as

$$\Phi(S) = \frac{\sum_{i \in S, j \notin S} a_{ij}}{min(\sum_{i \in S} \delta(i), \sum_{i \notin S} \delta(i))} = \frac{\sum_{i \in S, j \notin S} a_{ij}}{min(|S|, |V(\mathcal{G}) \backslash S|)},$$

where $\delta(i) = \sum_{j \in V(\mathcal{G})} a_{ij} = 1$. The numerator is the sum of the weights of the edges from S to $V(\mathcal{G}) \backslash S$, i.e. it describes how much combined weight the nodes in S give to those in $V(\mathcal{G}) \backslash S$. Therefore, the conductance of a set of nodes S measures the connectedness of S and $V(\mathcal{G}) \backslash S$ compared to how connected the sets are themselves. For a graph $\mathcal{G}$, its conductance is defined as $\Phi(\mathcal{G}) = \min_{S \subset V(\mathcal{G})} \Phi(S)$. Thus, if the conductance of a graph $\mathcal{G}$ is low, there exists a partition of the nodes into two sets (S and $V(\mathcal{G}) \backslash S$)), such that the nodes $i, j \in S$ or $i, j \notin S$ are highly connected, while nodes $i \in S$, $j \notin S$ are only sparsely connected. However, if the conductance of the graph $\mathcal{G}$ is large, then the entirety of $\mathcal{G}$ is highly connected. As shown in [4], this measure of conductance can be used to find the upper and lower bounds

$$\frac{\Phi^2}{8} \leq 1 - \lambda_2 \leq \Phi,$$

for the eigenvalue λ_2. These bounds imply that a higher conductance, i.e. connectedness, of the graph, results in a higher spectral gap and therefore smaller eigenvalue λ_2.

Because we observed that λ_2 is an upper bound for the convergence rate of our model, in section 3.1.4, we can conclude that highly connected graphs tend to converge faster, than sparsely connected ones.

4 Extensions of the DeGroot model

While the DeGroot model manages to describe the formation of a group consensus, as shown in section 3, it consists only of a very simple setup. The only mechanism used to simulate the formation of a consensus is the revision of the opinion value vector $\boldsymbol{p_0}$, as shown in eq. (2), which merely takes the initial weights into account, that the individuals assign to one another at the beginning of the process.

As, however, the formation of opinions in real social groups is far more complex than this iterative process, we will look at a few extensions which try to simulate further features of social interaction.

4.1 Friedkin-Johnsen model: Stubborn agents

The Friedkin-Johnsen model, as introduced in [1] and later expanded upon in [6], aims to integrate the phenomenon of interpersonal influences into the DeGroot model. This phenomenon describes the social influence of groups on their members through the encouragement of conformity and discouragement of nonconformity.

The basic idea of the Friedkin-Johnsen model is to simulate the impact of these interpersonal influences by using *susceptibility* as an additional metric. The *susceptibilty* of an individual i, denoted as d_i, describes how likely this individual is to change their opinion, i.e. the metric $1 - d_i$ describes how *stubborn* or unlikely the individual is to change their opinion. A fully stubborn individual i for example, would have $1 - d_i = 1$, while a fully susceptible individual j would have $1 - d_i = 0$. To use this metric of *susceptibility* in the model, we introduce the matrix

$$D = \begin{bmatrix} d_1 & \dots & 0 \\ \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & \dots & d_n \end{bmatrix} .$$

The interpersonal influences themselves are then expressed through the matrix $\boldsymbol{A}$, used in the DeGroot model, see section 3.

Just like the DeGroot model, the Friedkin-Johnsen model uses an iterative process to revise the opinion values of the individuals of the group. The revised opinion values for the kth revision are calculated as follows.

$$\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{DAp_{k-1}} + (\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{D})\boldsymbol{p_0} \tag{9}$$

If the eq. (9) is used iteratively to repeat the revisions, we obtain

$$\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{V_{k-1}}\boldsymbol{p_0} , \tag{10}$$

where

$$\boldsymbol{V}_{k-1} = (\boldsymbol{DA})^{k-1} + [\sum_{l=0}^{k-2} (\boldsymbol{DA})^l](\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{A}) . \tag{11}$$

If the model converges, i.e. $\lim_{k\to\infty} \boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{p^{fin}}$ exists, then similar to eq. (3)

$$\begin{aligned} \boldsymbol{p^{fin}} &= \boldsymbol{DAp^{fin}} + (\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{D})\boldsymbol{p_0} \\ &\iff (\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})\boldsymbol{p^{fin}} = (\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{D})\boldsymbol{p_0} , \end{aligned} \tag{12}$$

as for large enough k, $\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{p_{k-1}}$. Therefore, if $(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})$ is invertible, then

$$\boldsymbol{p^{fin}} = (\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})^{-1}(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{D})\boldsymbol{p_0} . \tag{13}$$

Let us assume that at least one $d_i < 1$, otherwise $\boldsymbol{D} = \boldsymbol{I}$ and thus eq. (9) is $\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{Ap_{k-1}}$ which is precisely eq. (2), i.e. the model is identical to the DeGroot model. Under this assumption, $(\boldsymbol{DA})$ is row-substochastic, meaning all row-sums are at most 1 and there is at least one row-sum that is strictly less than 1. According to [3], a row-substochastic matrix $\boldsymbol{M}$ is convergent if $\boldsymbol{M}$ is irreducible. Let us now define the following series

$$\boldsymbol{S}_n = \sum_{k=0}^{n} (\boldsymbol{DA})^k = \boldsymbol{I} + \boldsymbol{DA} + \dots + (\boldsymbol{DA})^n .$$

We can rearrange $(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})\boldsymbol{S}_n = (\boldsymbol{S}_n - \boldsymbol{DAS}_n) = (\boldsymbol{I} - (\boldsymbol{DA})^{n+1})$. If we assume that $(\boldsymbol{DA})$ is irreducible and therefore convergent, we know that $\lim_{n\to\infty} \boldsymbol{S}_n = \boldsymbol{S^{fin}}$ exists. Thus, $\lim_{n\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{I}-\boldsymbol{DA})\boldsymbol{S}_n = (\boldsymbol{I}-\boldsymbol{DA})\boldsymbol{S^{fin}}$ is well-defined and $(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})\boldsymbol{S^{fin}} = \boldsymbol{I}$, as $\lim_{n\to\infty}(\boldsymbol{DA})^{n+1} = \boldsymbol{0_{n\times n}}$. Therefore, we can conclude that $(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})$ is invertible if $\boldsymbol{DA}$ is irreducible.

In case $(\boldsymbol{I} - \boldsymbol{DA})$ is not invertible and $\boldsymbol{p^{fin}}$ exists, we can calculate $\boldsymbol{p^{fin}}$ by iteratively applying eq. (10) until a sufficiently large k is reached. [6]

4.2 Bounded confidence models

People often tend to engage more with others who align closely with their own opinion. Selection and conformation biases are two very well known factors that influence a person's formation of opinions. They both describe how people have a tendency to assign higher weight to information which favors their own opinion. Another effect of this dynamic is that, if an individual i strongly objects to an opinion held by individual j, it is likely that i will stop interacting with j. The limit for which an opinion can differ for individual i to still engage with that opinion, is referred to as the bounded confidence ϵ_i of i.

To simulate this dynamic, we will take a look at the Hegselmann-Krause model. Unlike the DeGroot model, this model assumes that each individual places an equal weight to all the opinion values of all other individuals that hold similar opinions. Thus, we can define a set of neighbours $N_i^k = \{1 \le j \le n \mid |v_{ik} - v_{jk}| < \epsilon_i\}$, that contains all individuals that i interacts with, i.e. that have a sufficiently similar opinion to i, in revision k. Therefore, a revision in the Hegselmann-Krause model is calculated as

$$v_{k+1} = \frac{1}{|N_i^k|} \sum_{j \in N_i^k} v_{jk} . \tag{14}$$

We can observe that the revised value for a given v_{ik}, is the average opinion value of all neighbours of i in revision $k-1$. Moreover, by redefining our adjacency matrix $\boldsymbol{A} \in \mathbb{R}_{n\times n}$ as

$$(\boldsymbol{A}_k)_{ij} = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{|N_i^k|} & \text{if } j \in N_i^k, \\ 0 & \text{else.} \end{cases},$$

then we can calculate the revision through $\boldsymbol{p_k} = \boldsymbol{A_k p_{k-1}}$, similar to eq. (2).

Notice that this model describes a DeGroot model, where all outgoing edges from a certain node have the same weight and edges between two nodes can be added and removed depending on the simularity of their opinion values.

Furthermore, to observe under which conditions the Hegselmann-Krause model reaches asymptotic consensus, we define an ϵ-chain, similar to [7] and [8].

Definition 4.1 (ϵ-chain). *A vector $\boldsymbol{p} \in \mathbb{R}_+^n$ is called an ϵ-chain with $\epsilon \geq 0$ if an ordering $v_{1i} \leq \cdots \leq v_{ni}$ exists such that $v_{(k+1)i} - v_{ki} \leq \epsilon$ for all $k \in \underline{n}$.*

With this defintion, we can show in the following that the Hegselmann-Krause model reaches asymptotic consensus if and only if the vector $_{p_k}$ is an ϵ_{max}-chain for all revisions k, for $\epsilon_{max} = \max_{i\in\underline{n}} \epsilon_i$.

Proof. Let us assume that p_k are ϵ_{max}-chains for all revisions k. First, we will prove by induction that the sequences $v_k^{max} = v_{jk}$ with $v_j = \max_{i\in\underline{n}} v_i$ and $v_k^{min} = v_{j'k}$ with $v_{j'} = \min_{i\in\underline{n}} v_i$, i.e. the opinion values in revision k of the individuals with the highest and lowest initial opinion values, are an upper/lower bound for all other opinion values $v_k^{min} \leq v_{ik} \leq v_k^{max}$ for all $i \in \underline{n}$. This statement is trivially true for $k = 0$, as v_0^{max} and v_0^{min} are precisely defined, as the largest and smallest of the initial opinion values. Assume that the statement is correct for any $k \in \mathbb{N}$. For any revision $k+1$ let us assume that there exists a $j \in \underline{n}$ such that $v_{j(k+1)} > v_{k+1}^{max}$. Notice that if $i \in N_{max}^{k+1}$ and $l \in N_j^k$ with $v_{lk} \geq v_{ik}$ then $l \in N_{max}^k$ as l must be in the bounded confidence ϵ_{max}. Thus $avg_{i\in N_{max}^k}(v_{ik}) \geq avg_{i\in N_j^k}(v_{ik})$, i.e. the average opinion value of the neighbours of v_k^{max} are greater the average opinion value of the neighbours of v_{jk}. As we observed for eq. (14), the revised values v_{k+1}^{max} and $v_{j(k+1)}$ are the averages of the opinion values of the neighbours of max and j in revision k. As $avg_{i\in N_{max}^k}(v_{ik}) \geq avg_{i\in N_j^k}(v_{ik})$, therefore $v_{k+1}^{max} \geq v_{j(k+1)}$. The same argument can be used to show that v_k^{min} is a lower bound. Now, we will show that v_k^{max} and v_k^{min} are strictly increasing and decreasing sequences. We have shown that v_k^{max} is an upper bound for all opinion values in revision k. Because p_k is assumed to be an ϵ-chain, there exists at least one v_{jk} with $j \in N_{max}^k$ and for all $i \in N_{max}^k$, $v_{ik} \leq v_k^{max}$. Thus $v_{k+1}^{max} = \frac{1}{|N_{max}^k|}\sum_{i\in N_{max}^k} v_{ik} \leq v_k^{max}$, i.e. v_k^{max} is a strictly decreasing sequence. Because v_k^{max} and v_k^{max} are upper and lower bounds as well as strictly decreasing or increasing, it must follow that p_k converges asymptotically for $k \to \infty$. □

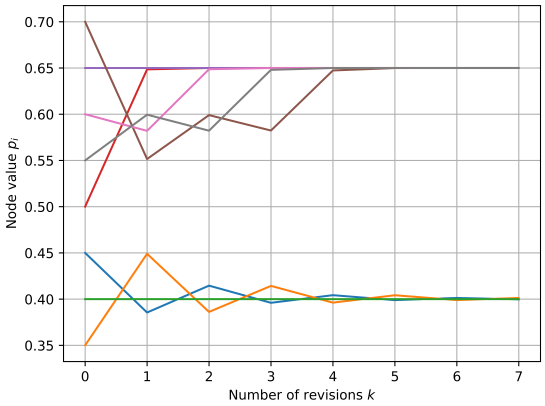


Fig. 4. The convergence of the model with the adjacency matrix shown in table 1 and a threshold of $m_c = 0.23$. This removal of edges causes the corresponding graph to be split into two sinks.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, we examine the DeGroot model to analyze the formation of opinions in groups. We then showed under which conditions the model converges, and more specifically when it converges towards a consensus. Furthermore, we look at how network properties can be used to determine the convergence properties of the model. Lastly, we expand on the DeGroot model examining the effect of additional features, such as *susceptibility*, *confidence bounds*, and *biased agents*, by comparing them to the results of the original model.

In the future, the possible extensions could be further elaborated by taking additional phenomena into account, such as repulsive behaviour ("negative weights" which could change an individual's opinion value in the opposite direction of the one, with whom they interacted), as done in [9], interrelated topics (a subject rarely exists in isolation but rather in interaction with other topics), as done in [10], or a distinction between publicly versus privately expressed opinions (some opinions, especially on highly stigmatized topics, are often expressed only to certain individuals), as done in [11].

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